If fresh chestnuts aren't in season, use canned whole unsweetened chestnuts or dried peeled ones. You could also use pancetta or bacon instead of ham.

chestnut soup with ham

SERVES 4 **PREP** 30 MINS **COOK** 45 MINS **FREEZE** UP TO 3 MONTHS WITHOUT THE HAM GARNISH

1lb 5oz (600g) fresh chestnuts
1½–2 tbsp sunflower, peanut, or mild-flavored olive oil
¾ oz (20g) butter
½ Spanish onion, finely chopped
1 garlic clove, crushed
3 bay leaves
2 tsp dried fennel seeds, plus 1 heaping tsp, to garnish
sea salt and freshly ground black pepper
1¼ quarts (1¼ liters) light vegetable stock
3½ oz (100g) slice of cooked ham, diced
1½ tbsp mascarpone, to finish (optional)

1 Score each chestnut with a small sharp knife (see below left), then place in a saucepan, cover with cold water, and bring to a boil. Drain, set aside until cool enough to handle, then peel and set aside. (You could also peel them using the microwave method on the opposite page.)

2 Place a large, heavy-based saucepan over medium heat. Add the oil and half the butter. Cook the onion and garlic until golden and softened, about 2–3 minutes, stirring frequently. Add the peeled chestnuts, the bay leaves, and the 2 tsp fennel seeds. Stir and season with salt and pepper. Pour in the stock. Bring to a gentle simmer, partly cover, and cook for 20–30 minutes, stirring occasionally, until the chestnuts are soft.

3 Leave to cool. Discard the bay leaves. Transfer the soup to a blender or food processor and process until smooth. Strain the soup through a sieve back into the pan, pressing with the back of a spoon. Gently reheat the soup.

4 Meanwhile, place a nonstick frying pan over fairly low heat. Add the reserved butter, and then add the diced ham and the extra fennel seeds. Cook gently, stirring a few times. Taste and adjust the seasoning. Stir the soup and ladle it into bowls. Scatter over a little of the diced ham and fennel seeds. If you like, add a small dollop of mascarpone to each serving.